ARTIST REFERENCE

# Tattoo Artist Cheat Sheet

Right needle, right depth, clean lines and a traceable ink lot.

## Needle groupings

| CODE | GROUPING | BEST FOR | WATCH FOR |
|---|---|---|---|
| **RL** | Round liner | Outlines, lettering, detail | 1RL is single needle. Tight = crisper. |
| **RS** | Round shader | Bold lines, small shaded areas | Looser cluster. Don't overwork. |
| **M1** | Magnum (weaved) | Shading and color fill, big areas | Two staggered rows. Corners can scar. |
| **CM** | Curved magnum | Smooth blends, soft gradients | Also RM. Gentler on the skin. |
| **BP** | Bugpin · taper | Fine lines, soft shading | #10 (0.30 mm) needles; finer flow. |
| **F** | Flat | Geometric fill, crisp edges | One straight row. Keep the angle. |

## Line, shade & pack

| TECHNIQUE | HAND AND PASSES | GOAL · COMMON MISTAKE |
|---|---|---|
| **Lining** | Steady, one confident pass | Solid line at even depth. Too deep blows out; too shallow skips. |
| **Shading** | Light layers, whip or pendulum | Smooth gradients. Overworking scars and slows healing. |
| **Color packing** | Small, slow overlapping circles | Full saturation. Stop when skin turns shiny and puffy. |

## Placement: pain level and risk

| ●●○○○ | ●●●○○ | ●●●○○ | ●●●●● | ●●●●● | ●●●●○ | ●●●●○ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Outer arm** | **Forearm** | **Thigh** | **Ribs** | **Sternum** | **Hands · fingers** | **Feet · ankles** |
| Easy starter | Inner side thin | Inner side thin | Stretch firmly | Bony, sensitive | Fades fast | Blowout, fading |

## Wrap options compared

| WRAP | WEAR TIME | PROS · WATCH FOR |
|---|---|---|
| **Plastic wrap** | [2–5] hours | Cheap and familiar. Not breathable; off the same day. |
| **Non-stick pad** | [2–5] hours | Absorbs fluid. Can stick if left on too long. |
| **Second-skin film** | 8–24 h, then up to [6] days | Fewer washes. Ask about adhesive allergy; never over 7 days total. |

### SKIN & DEPTH

- **Depth:** ink sits in the upper dermis, about [1–2] mm.
- Thin or older skin: lighter hand, fewer passes.
- Keloid history: small test area first.
- Scars: wait until fully mature, about [12] months.
- Moles: work around them, never over.
- Stretchy areas: stretch firmly and evenly.

### INK STORAGE & RECALLS

- **Log brand, color, lot # and expiry** per client.
- Store sealed, cool and dark; date when opened.
- Discard expired ink. Check FDA recalls [monthly].
- Single-use caps; never pour ink back.
- EU/UK: REACH-compliant inks with batch number.
- Recall? Pull the lot and check client records.

**Every time.** Follow maker instructions and health department rules. Depths are a guide; adjust to each client.